

The Speculative Welfare State and Transmedia Melancholy:

The Aesthetic, Narrative, and Sonic Architecture of Simon Stålenhag

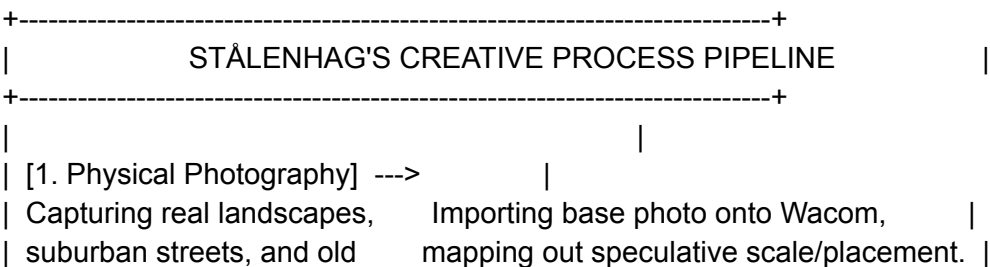
Source guide

This text provides a comprehensive overview of the multidisciplinary career of Simon Stålenhag, a Swedish artist renowned for his "kitchen sink science fiction" and the creation of false nostalgia. It details his unique technical process of merging physical photography with digital painting to depict a speculative welfare state where ordinary rural life is juxtaposed with decaying, high-tech ruins. The source chronologically examines his five narrative art books, tracking a thematic evolution from childhood wonder and societal disintegration to intimate explorations of queer romance and memory. Furthermore, it explores Stålenhag's diverse creative output beyond illustration, including his analog-inspired electronic music, scientific paleoart, and the complex, sometimes contentious, transition of his intellectual property into tabletop games and major film adaptations. Ultimately, the text illustrates how Stålenhag uses surreal machinery as a powerful metaphor for the collapse of 20th-century utopian ideals and the persistent isolation of the modern human condition.

Simon Stålenhag has established himself as a central figure in contemporary digital art and speculative fiction, defining a genre often termed "kitchen sink science fiction" or Scandinavian retro-futurism.[1, 2, 3] Born on January 20, 1984, in the Stockholm archipelago of Mälardalen, Sweden, Stålenhag's early experiences on the rural island of Färingsö deeply shaped his artistic perspective.[1, 3, 4] Moving to this rural landscape at age three, he developed a deep connection to the wide, cold Nordic horizons, wooded expanses, and fading industrial structures that characterized late-twentieth-century Sweden.[1, 2, 3] This childhood environment, combined with an early interest in landscape illustration, cinema, and tabletop role-playing games, provided the foundation for his alternate-history worlds.[2, 3, 4] Stålenhag's work does not simply depict speculative technology; it explores the psychological and cultural decline of the Swedish social democratic welfare state, known as the Folkhemmet.[1, 4] This analysis details Stålenhag's narrative art books, his technical and painterly methods, his extensive musical compositions under Sätuna Sound Team, and the complex transmedia adaptations of his intellectual property in tabletop gaming, television, and film.[4, 5, 6]

Technical Pipeline, Color Theory, and the Emulation of Analog Mediums

Stålenhag's unique aesthetic relies on creating "false nostalgia"—a psychological response where viewers experience a deep, collective yearning for an alternate past that never existed.[2] This emotional resonance is constructed through a careful technical workflow that fuses physical photography with digital painting to replicate the imperfections of analog media.[2, 4]



	Saab/Volvo vehicles.[4]	[1, 4]	
		v	
	<---		
	Simulating gouache, oil	Preserving visible "handwriting" of	
	pigment decay, and analog	the artist, rejecting clinical vector	
	film chemical fade.[2]	perfection.[4, 7]	
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Stålenhag's process begins with physical photography.[2, 4] He travels through rural Sweden and the American West, capturing high-resolution photos of empty roads, utility poles, and suburban residential blocks.[1, 3, 4] These photos serve as the structural base for his digital canvas.[4, 7] Using a Wacom tablet and a computer, he imports the photos and drafts digital sketches to determine the placement and scale of speculative elements like colossal cooling towers, abandoned mechs, or prehistoric fauna.[1, 4]

To avoid the clean, sterile look common in digital art, Stålenhag uses custom brushes designed to emulate physical gouache and oil painting.[4, 7] He focuses on preserving a distinct "handwriting" in his brushstrokes, maintaining visible edges, varying stroke weights, and mimicking organic pigment behaviors.[4, 7]

The mood of his landscapes is governed by a distinct approach to color theory.[2, 8] His environments are frequently bathed in the pastel light of "eternal twilights"—the soft, diffused illumination of early mornings, late afternoons, or overcast winter days.[2, 3] He relies on a muted color palette dominated by cold blues, pale pinks, faded oranges, and earthy, weathered browns.[2, 8]

To simulate analog film, Stålenhag recreates the chemical fading of vintage photography, which gives his paintings the appearance of discovered historical records.[2] He uses mist, fog, and atmospheric haze to soften background details, which helps establish depth while shrouding his massive speculative structures in a quiet, haunting ambiguity.[2, 3, 8]

A key part of Stålenhag's visual storytelling is the tension between everyday realism and surreal speculative elements.[2] Rather than depicting a clean, hyper-advanced future, he shows speculative technology as ordinary, consumer-grade, and ultimately prone to decay.[2, 9]

To ground these elements, Stålenhag incorporates familiar details of twentieth-century working-class life, such as old Volvo and Saab cars, alongside massive, rusting cargo vessels and experimental military facilities.[4, 7, 10] This juxtaposition of ordinary domestic life with failing, advanced technology highlights the themes of unfulfilled utopian planning that run through his work.[2]

Chronological Analysis of the Narrative Art Books

Stålenhag's five narrative art books show a clear progression in his storytelling.[3, 4, 11] Over time, his books have moved from fragmented, nostalgic vignettes of childhood toward more cohesive, linear, and emotionally complex narratives.[12, 13, 14]

Book Title (Swedish / English)	Publication Year	Primary Setting & Eras	Narrative Focus	Key Thematic Elements
Ur varselklotet / Tales from the Loop [4, 15]	2014 [4]	Alternate 1980s Mäläröarna, Sweden [4, 16]	Vignettes of children exploring anomalies near an underground facility [12, 16]	Childhood alienation, failed promises of modernity, techno-nostalgia [2, 4]
Flodskörden / Things from the Flood [4, 15]	2016 [4]	Alternate 1990s Mäläröarna, Sweden [13]	Teenagers surviving toxic spills and biomechanical "machine cancer" [3, 13]	Bodily anxiety, biological decay, puberty, societal disintegration [3, 13]
Passagen / The Electric State [4, 15]	2017 [17]	Alternate 1997 Pacifica, United States [4, 18]	A runaway teenager and her toy robot driving across a decaying country [4, 18]	Late-stage capitalism, neurocaster addiction, societal collapse [19]

Labyrinten / The Labyrinth [4, 15]	2020 [17]	Ash-covered, ruined surface and underground enclaves [20, 21]	An expedition across a devastated landscape [20, 21]	Claustrophobia, isolation, psychological collapse, futile cycle of violence [22]
Swedish Machines / Sunset at Zero Point [4, 11]	2025 [11]	Alternate early 2000s Mäläröarna, Sweden [11]	A multi-decade slow-burn relationship near a non-Euclidean exclusion zone [11, 12, 23]	Queer intimacy, masculinity, emotional barriers, memory [11, 14, 23]

Tales from the Loop (2014)

Tales from the Loop (Ur varselklotet) introduces Stålenhag's alternate-history Sweden, where the government constructed the world's largest particle accelerator deep below the pastoral landscape of Mäläröarna in 1969.[4, 16, 24] This subterranean facility, known as "The Loop," causes gravity-defying anomalies, rogue automatons, and interdimensional rifts to surface in the surrounding countryside.[2, 16, 24]

The book is structured as a collection of fragmented childhood memories, with short written vignettes accompanying each illustration.[12, 13] The story focuses on local preteens who explore these technological ruins while dealing with everyday struggles like schoolyard bullying, domestic boredom, and distant, emotionally detached parents.[16, 24]

The science fiction elements serve as metaphors for the alienation of childhood.[4, 7, 10] The massive cooling towers of the Loop rising above typical suburban homes reflect the isolating, monolithic authority of the adult world to children who are largely left to fend for themselves.[4, 14, 16]

Things from the Flood (2016)

The direct sequel, Things from the Flood (Flodskörden), moves the setting into the 1990s, capturing a darker and more chaotic period of transition.[4, 13] The Loop has been decommissioned, but the abandoned facility begins to overflow with dark, toxic water that floods the rural countryside, carrying strange biomechanical entities.[3, 13]

The book shifts away from the nostalgic wonder of its predecessor toward bodily and psychological horror.[3, 13] Speculative machinery is now afflicted with "machine cancer," sprouting organic, tumorous growths that distort their original designs.[3, 13]

This physical corruption serves as a metaphor for the anxieties of puberty and adolescence, where the characters' bodies and environments undergo unsettling, uncontrollable changes.[13]

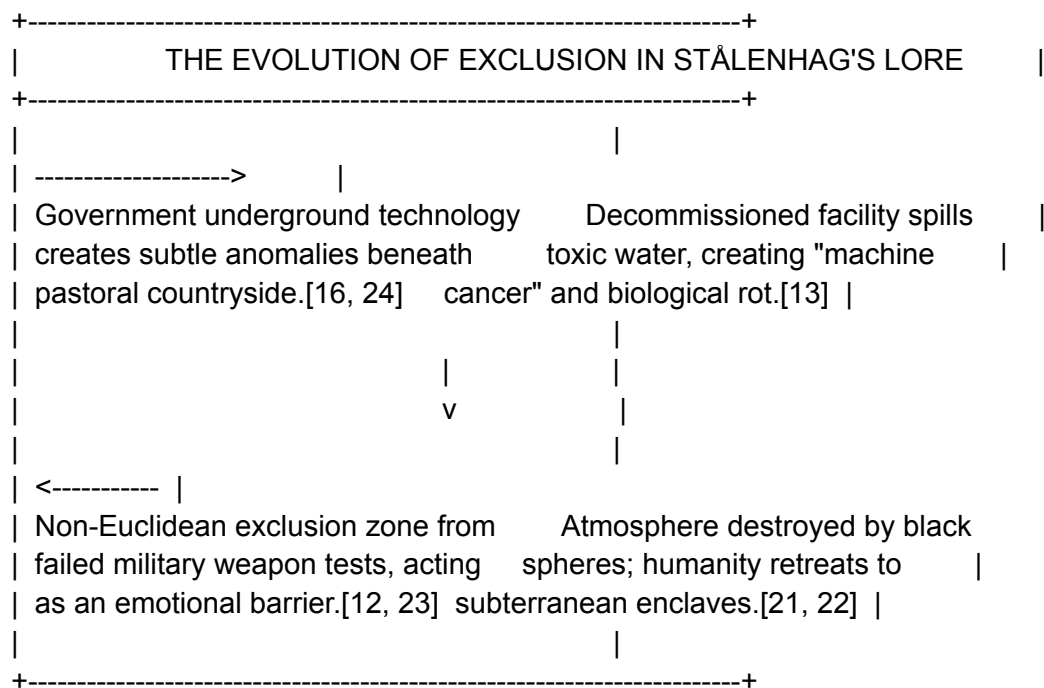
The broader setting also reflects the decline of the traditional Swedish welfare model, showing a local community dealing with economic instability, schoolyard hazings, and the steady encroachment of globalization.[3, 13]

The Electric State (2017)

For *The Electric State* (originally published in Sweden as *Passagen*), Stålenhag shifted his setting to the western United States during an alternate 1997.[4, 15, 18] The book follows Michelle, a runaway teenager, and her yellow toy robot as they drive west across the fictional state of Pacifica.[4, 18, 19] The desert landscape is littered with the massive wreckage of battle drones, left over from a devastating civil war.[18, 19, 25]

Stålenhag's early conceptual notes reveal that his original idea, under the working title "Black Yield" (reflected in his files by the prefix "BY"), centered on exotic matter created by weapons of mass destruction on US soil.[26] This idea eventually evolved into the "neurocaster"—a highly addictive virtual reality headset that links human minds into a massive, collective digital network.[19, 25, 26]

As Michelle travels west, she encounters a society that has completely unraveled.[18, 19] Neurocaster users sit decaying in plastic chairs, their minds permanently jacked into the digital network while their physical environments fall apart alongside heaps of consumer trash and massive commercial advertisements.[19, 25] The book presents a cynical critique of consumerism, technological addiction, and the collapse of community under late-stage capitalism.[12, 13, 19]



The Labyrinth (2020)

The Labyrinth (*Labyrinten*) is Stålenhag's most claustrophobic work, exploring themes of isolation and psychological collapse.[12, 22, 27] The Earth's atmosphere has been ravaged by an unexplainable cosmic phenomenon, where massive floating black spheres have descended

to cover the surface in ash and strange coral forests.[21, 22] The surviving remnants of humanity have fled into sterile, subterranean enclaves.[21, 22]

The story follows three individuals—two scientists, Matt and Sigrid, and a silent boy named Charlie—as they travel in an eight-wheeled vehicle to conduct a surface expedition.[20, 21]

Rather than focusing on a heroic survival effort, the narrative is an intimate, unsettling study of isolation and how violence can breed more violence.[22]

Stålenhag uses a "sequenced art" technique, displaying consecutive pages containing the same basic illustration with only tiny, deliberate shifts.[22] This repetition mimics the psychological monotony of underground confinement, building tension that culminates in personal tragedy.[20, 22]

Sunset at Zero Point (2025)

Published by Saga Press on December 9, 2025, *Sunset at Zero Point* (developed under the working title *Swedish Machines*) returns Stålenhag to his native Stockholm archipelago of Mälardarna.[4, 11] Set largely during the early 2000s, the book is structured as a multi-decade, slow-burn queer romance between two childhood friends, Linus and Valter.[11, 12, 23] They grow up near "Black Fallow"—a fenced-off military exclusion zone created by a failed weapons test that left behind non-Euclidean geography and abandoned military installations.[11, 12, 23] While his earlier books used science fiction to show broad societal decline, *Sunset at Zero Point* uses its speculative environment as a personal metaphor for emotional barriers and vulnerability.[11, 14, 23] The non-Euclidean anomalies are not active threats; they are quiet, decaying backdrops to the characters' struggles with masculinity, sexuality, and the weight of memory.[11, 23]

The artwork is more subdued than in his previous books, placing the massive military structures in the background to focus on the quiet, personal moments between two men trying to connect.[12, 14, 23]

Technical Emulation vs. Generative Artificial Intelligence

The rising popularity of machine learning has made Stålenhag's work a common style benchmark for generative models, particularly Midjourney.[8] Midjourney styles often reference "Simon Stålenhag" alongside terms like "Epic Visions Atelier," "Kilian Eng," and "Liar Game" to generate detailed, speculative landscapes.[8]

However, these generative attempts struggle to capture the intentional structure of Stålenhag's compositions.[2] AI models can replicate surface details like rusted metal, old cars, and muted blue-and-orange color palettes.[2, 8] Yet, they lack the deliberate spatial design and analog film emulation that Stålenhag uses to create "false nostalgia".[2]

Stålenhag's compositions rely on a careful balance between hyper-realistic details and speculative elements, using natural brushstrokes to maintain an organic, human quality that digital generators often replace with clinical, mathematical patterns.[2, 4, 7]

Interactive Portfolios, Scientific Illustration, and Creative Disputes

Stålenhag's creative work extends beyond narrative art books into game design, scientific illustration, and collaborative covers.[4, 7]

Ripple Dot Zero (2013)

Before his art books received widespread recognition, Stålenhag spent five years collaborating with his childhood friend, programmer Tommy Salomonsson, to develop Ripple Dot Zero.[4, 28] Released by Pixeltruss and featured on Newgrounds in July 2013, the game is a browser-based, browser-playable 2D action platformer built as a tribute to 16-bit Sega Genesis classics like Sonic the Hedgehog, Strider, and Wonder Boy in Monster World.[28, 29, 30] Stålenhag served as the game's lead artist, level designer, and composer, while Tommy Salomonsson handled programming and Nils Flodin contributed additional programming.[31] Players control a sword-slashing penguin on a mission to rescue small creatures called "ripples" from a high-tech laboratory.[28, 31]

The game spans 12 levels and features hidden bonus stages unlocked by collecting capsules.[31] The level mechanics incorporate springs, jetpacks, and throwing blades, leading up to a battle with a "leaping robot" boss.[31] Stålenhag composed the game's FM synthesis soundtrack to recreate the distinct audio style of the early 1990s.[29, 32]

STÅLENHAG'S INTERACTIVE & SCIENTIFIC PROJECTS			
PROJECT TITLE	YEAR	PARTNERS / INSTITUTIONS	AESTHETIC STYLE
Ripple Dot Zero	2013	Tommy Salomonsson, Pixeltruss [28, 31]	16-bit Genesis pixel art style [29]
Paleoart Exhibition	2014	Swedish Museum of Natural History [33]	Naturalistic oil landscape [4, 7]
No Man's Sky Promo	2015	Hello Games [5, 26]	Retro-futuristic space exploration [5]

Scientific and Ecological Illustration

Stålenhag has also used his digital painting style to illustrate scientific and environmental subjects [4, 7]:

- **Paleoart Exhibition (2014):** Reconnecting with a childhood interest, Stålenhag contacted the Swedish Museum of Natural History in Stockholm to collaborate on their permanent Fossils & Evolution exhibition.[4, 7, 33] He worked with senior curators, including paleobotanist Stephen McLoughlin and vertebrate curator Thomas Mörs, to produce 28 scientifically accurate paintings of prehistoric life.[33] These works depict creatures like Dimetrodon, Coelophysis, and Tyrannosaurus Rex within soft, realistic landscapes.[34] These illustrations were later published in the 2019 book *Urtidsbilder*, with text by science journalist Anna Davour.[17, 33]
- **Stockholm Resilience Centre (2016):** Commissioned by Stockholm University's environmental research hub, Stålenhag produced a series of paintings illustrating the potential impacts of rising sea levels under climate change.[7, 10] These works depict

familiar Swedish coastal towns partially submerged by dark water, translating scientific projections into clear visual scenes.[2, 7, 26]

Tabletop RPG Cover Art

In addition to his narrative books, Stålenhag has contributed cover art for several tabletop games published by Free League Publishing [17, 26]:

- Mutant Year Zero (2015): Cover art for the updated edition of the classic Swedish post-apocalyptic RPG, which originally inspired his childhood drawings.[3, 26]
- Mutant Year Zero: Elysium (2016): Cover art depicting subterranean military enclaves.[26]
- Forbidden Lands Player's Handbook (2018): Cover art for Free League's retro fantasy RPG.[17, 26]

The Generation Zero Dispute

In late August 2018, a public dispute arose between Stålenhag and Avalanche Studios regarding their open-world video game Generation Zero.[35, 36]

When Avalanche released gameplay trailers, fans and journalists noted clear visual similarities to Tales from the Loop: both were set in the rural Swedish countryside during the late 1980s, both featured teenagers, and both centered on massive, blocky combat robots patrolling near red wooden houses.[35, 36, 37]

Stålenhag expressed frustration over the situation, clarifying that his concern was not copyright infringement, but the confusion it caused among his fans.[35, 36] He was flooded with questions asking if he was involved in the game or if the studio had consulted him.[35, 36] He pointed out that Avalanche was based in the same town, the game's director Emil Kraftling followed him on Twitter, and he had briefly worked with the studio on a separate project.[35, 36] Stålenhag argued that the studio should have publicly clarified his lack of involvement.[35, 36]

Emil Kraftling denied that Stålenhag's work served as an inspiration, claiming the game was born out of the development team's shared memories of growing up in Sweden during the 1980s.[36, 37] Kraftling stated that the studio had contacted Stålenhag's agency, and that there was an acknowledgment that no copyright infringement had occurred.[36]

Stålenhag refuted this, stating that neither he nor his agency had ever formally accused Avalanche of copyright infringement, and that the studio's refusal to publicly address the confusion was a disappointing lack of professional courtesy.[35, 36]

Soundtracks and Musical Discography

Stålenhag is also an accomplished electronic musician.[1, 4] Writing under his own name and his musical alias, Sätuna Sound Team, he composes synth and ambient soundtracks to accompany his narrative books.[4, 5]

The Electric State (2017)

Released as a backer goal for the book's Kickstarter campaign, this self-released electronic album features tracks like "Pacifica Welcomes You," "Lake Esquagama," and "The Smokestacks of Kingston".[4, 38] The soundtrack relies on sweeping synth pads and slow analog arpeggios, capturing the lonely, desolate atmosphere of Michelle's journey across Pacifica.[4, 39]

Music for DOS (2018)

For his second album, Stålenhag restricted his production tools, using old keyboards and the legacy MS-DOS tracker software Impulse Tracker.[4] The tracks, including "Casio Patterns One"

and "Memory Block," feature low-fidelity, chip-tune textures and rigid step-sequenced patterns.[38, 40] This technical choice matches his retro-futuristic aesthetic, capturing the sound of early personal computers.[4, 40]

Music for Satanic Children (2021)

This album features a more experimental and heavy synthesizer style.[39, 41] It moves away from pleasant nostalgia toward unsettling soundscapes, echoing the shifting tone of his later literary works.[40, 41]

The Labyrinth (Official Soundtrack) (2021)

Composed to accompany his fourth book, this soundtrack consists of slow-moving, dark ambient drones and cold synthesized chords, as heard in the track "Ammonia Rain".[5, 40] The music is sparse and oppressive, translating the heavy, subterranean claustrophobia of the book into an acoustic experience.[22, 32, 40]

Tabletop Role-Playing Game Adaptations

Stålenhag's books have been adapted into tabletop role-playing games published by Free League Publishing.[1, 16, 19] These games utilize customized versions of the "Year Zero Engine"—a rules-light, pool-based system that prioritizes narrative momentum and atmosphere.[16, 24, 25]

Tales from the Loop RPG (2017)

The Tales from the Loop RPG places players in the roles of preteens (ages 10 to 15) in an alternate 1980s.[16, 24]

- The Core System: Players build characters based on classic suburban archetypes, such as the Bookworm, the Jock, the Troublemaker, the Popular Kid, and the Weirdo.[16, 24] Action resolution relies on rolling a pool of six-sided dice determined by combining an attribute and a skill.[16] Any rolled "6" represents a success.[16]
- The No-Death Mechanic: A key rule of the system is that the player characters cannot die.[16] Instead of a traditional health point tracker, taking physical damage or suffering emotional trauma inflicts "Conditions" such as Scared, Angry, Exhausted, or Injured.[16] Each active condition reduces the player's dice pool, making subsequent tasks progressively harder.[16]
- The Structure of Play: Sessions are divided into two contrasting modes of play: "Everyday Life" (dealing with parents, schoolwork, and chores) and "The Mystery" (escaping to investigate anomalies, rogue robots, and government conspiracies).[16, 24]

The core rulebook features a campaign called "The Four Seasons of Mad Science," which contains four linked mysteries: "Summer Break and Killer Birds," "Grown-Up Attraction," "Creatures from the Cretaceous," and "I, Wagner".[16]

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FREE LEAGUE STÅLENHAG RPG RELEASES		
+-----+		
CORE RULEBOOKS	CAMPAIGNS & COMPANIONS	
+-----+		
- *Tales from the Loop RPG* (2017)	- *Our Friends the Machines* (2017)	
[16, 24]	[27]	
- *Things from the Flood* (2019)	- *Out of Time* (2019) [27]	
[3, 21]	- *They Grow Up So Fast* (2023) [27]	
- *The Electric State RPG* (2024)		
[19, 25]		
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Companion Books and Scenarios

Free League has released several expansions to build on the core RPG setting [16, 27]:

- Our Friends the Machines (2017): This companion book offers rules for setting a Loop under the players' own hometowns.[27] It includes three scenarios: a rogue AI distributing itself through a new line of action figures, a PTA president using subliminal messages to brainwash a town (cured by heavy metal music), and the Loop acting as a conduit for interdimensional entities.[27]
- Out of Time (2019): A campaign focused on time travel mechanics.[27]
- They Grow Up So Fast (2023): A campaign structured around the discovery of a strange, alien pet.[27]

Screen Adaptations: The Tension Between Melancholy and Blockbuster Cinema

Stålenhag's visual storytelling has attracted major screen adaptations, though translating his quiet, atmospheric style into cinema has highlighted creative challenges.[6, 42]

Tales from the Loop (Amazon Prime, 2020)

The Amazon Prime television adaptation of Tales from the Loop is widely regarded as an artistic success that captured the quiet tone of the source material.[4, 6] Showrunner Nathaniel Halpern and cinematographer Jeff Cronenweth translated Stålenhag's static, pastel-toned digital paintings into moving imagery.[6]

The series rejected high-stakes action.[6] Instead, it used an anthology-style structure to explore themes of grief, aging, loneliness, and time.[6] By prioritizing silence, long takes, and emotional ambiguity, the television adaptation maintained a strong thematic fidelity to Stålenhag's original vision.[6]

The Electric State (Netflix, March 14, 2025)

In contrast, the feature film adaptation of The Electric State took a significantly different creative approach.[42, 43] Produced and directed by the Russo Brothers (AGBO) for Netflix, with a massive budget of \$320 million, the film was released on March 14, 2025, starring Millie Bobby Brown and Chris Pratt.[42, 43, 44]

The production faced a difficult development cycle, including a fatal off-set crew accident in 2022 and extensive reshoots stretching into 2024 across Atlanta, Moab, and Brazil.[44] Upon release, the film was met with highly negative reviews from critics, earning a 14% critical approval rating on Rotten Tomatoes.[43, 45]

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	THE ELECTRIC STATE: ADAPTATION COMPARISON
+-----+	
	ORIGINAL NOVEL (Simon Stålenhag) NETFLIX FILM (The Russo Brothers, 2025)
+-----+	
	- Elliptical and minimalist narrative - Obvious, highly expository screenplay
	- Muted, melancholic color palette - Garish, saturated, high-contrast CGI
	- Quiet, lonely road trip - Action-comedy team adventure
	- Sombre meditation on alienation - Human vs. robot conflict
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Critics criticized the film's departure from the quiet, melancholic tone of Stålenhag's novel.[42, 45] Elisabeth Vincentelli of The New York Times panned the film as "obvious, garish and just plain dumb" compared to the "elliptical, muted, melancholy" book.[42] Sam Adams of Slate called the end product disastrous, noting its high budget, while other reviews criticized the performances of Brown and Pratt as flat and one-dimensional.[42]

The film received Golden Raspberry (Razzies) nominations in March 2026 for Worst Picture, Worst Director, and Worst Screenplay.[42] While it achieved high streaming numbers on Netflix—accumulating 3.86 billion minutes viewed over nine months—it fell short of lower-budget original releases like Back in Action and Happy Gilmore 2.[45]

Conclusion

The works of Simon Stålenhag represent a significant study of the decline of twentieth-century technological optimism.[2, 4] By embedding colossal, decaying scientific infrastructure into rural landscapes, Stålenhag captures a distinct cultural shift: the slow, quiet unraveling of the social democratic welfare state under the pressure of late-stage capitalism and technological alienation.[2, 4, 19]

Through his digital paintings, ambient soundtracks, tabletop RPGs, and deeply personal books, Stålenhag does not merely illustrate science fiction.[1, 2, 4] He constructs monuments to a promised future that never arrived, leaving behind a quiet landscape of rusted machines, fading light, and the persistent, vulnerable struggle of those left behind to navigate the ruins.[2, 14, 23]

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